I never imagined, when I started, that I would have to conclude at such a terrible time. Yet this is the reality we are facing. Will Netanyahu be able to negotiate some acceptable compromise during the coming two months before the fanatics threaten him with the ruin of his coalition?

I am not competent enough to predict how badly the Israeli economy will be shaken in the next few months, how grievously the country's security will be imperiled, how catastrophically the health system will suffer, whether the two segments of society that are aligned against each other will ever find a path to some unity, and how the rational part of the population will, if needed, maintain its will to protest. These are ultimately the main issues. But let me, nonetheless, turn to the political scene.

Against all my dire prognostics and rational judgment, I wish to end on a whiff of optimism, very mild optimism, because the ongoing protests, if they continue, may ultimately lead to some positive results. Let me suggest, therefore, very tentatively, that in the not-too-distant future, the present governmental coalition will be torn apart from the inside. The Likud will turn into a party of the hard right and will not remain the most powerful party in the Knesset. Sooner or later Netanyahu will be out of politics and likely still busy with his remaining court cases and with his health.

A major question is whether Gantz and Lapid, if they are still around, might be able to establish a viable coalition of essentially liberal, centrist, and secular parties. On past form, it is not certain; their mutual animosity may be too strong for that. Given the usual division of the left, we could be in for a period of political chaos. The usual social resentments and religious and nationalist fanaticism will not, of course, disappear.

It was, I think, the great scholar of Kabbalah, Gershom Scholem, who wondered whether Jews would be able to shift from a messianic level of aspirations to that of practical politics. An active minority in Israel managed to operate at both levels: it adopted the most dangerous realpolitik and infused it with messianic ideology. Together with the hard right and the